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The consumer audio segment has never been so alive. Hustling and bustling with activity during the pandemic, audio manufacturers are consistently launching new products, each with better specs, feature sets, and designs. While the wired audio segment has seen a decline since wireless earphones took off, the overall segment is at an all-time high, even in India. With options aplenty, consumers may be confused about where to spend their hard-earned money. The consumer segment of audio products has products ranging from a few hundred rupees to ₹30-50K. A few years ago, the expensive audio products were the ones with the best quality and features, but now this is slowly trickling down to as low as ₹5,000! Budget wireless earphones were once plagued with incessant connectivity issues, but now, even ones costing as low as ₹2K have impeccable wireless connectivity due to wireless technologies getting more refined over time. The time to be smart with your dough

and buy value for money audio products is now, and it will only get better as time passes. However, what classifies as a value for money audio product and what must you look for? Let's delve into that.

HEADPHONES

There are two types of headphones or headsets predominantly found in the market – on-ear or supra aural headphones and over-ear or circumaural headphones. On-ear headphones, as the nomenclature indicates, sit directly on your ears while over-ear headphones completely surround your ear. While on-ear headphones are usually cheaper than over-ear ones, the only other advantage they have is that they're more portable than over-ear headphones. So, if portability is critical for your use, on-ear headphones could be a better deal for you.

However, there are numerous reasons we would suggest people to go for over-ear headphones

instead. Firstly, they have enough space to fit bigger drivers inside which does impact sound quality to an extent. They're also far more comfortable to wear and have higher bass impact and volume levels in general. Additionally, there's also less sound leakage in comparison to on-ear headphones. Manufacturers are also increasingly making circumaural headphones more portable over the years, allowing them to be folded and stored in relatively compact cases. So, in most cases, over-ear headphones not only provide you better comfort but also better sound, thereby becoming a more value-for-money purchase, even though they can be slightly more expensive than on-ear cans.

EARPHONES

If you would have asked us if cheap earphones were worth your money a few years ago, we would have said no with little to no hesitation. However, the story has changed drastically in the past few years. You still have ₹150-200 railway station earphones that won't last you more than a few days, or months (if you're incredibly lucky), and these are the ones that you shouldn't even consider given their delicate build and poor sound quality. However, budget earphone options between ₹500-3000 from established manufacturers such as Sennheiser, Sony, Realme, boAt, Boult Audio, Beyerdynamic, Xiaomi, and a



The Mi Dual Driver earphones cost merely ₹699 and come with a good number of basic features